

Stellar form: No pacer has picked up as many wickets (73) in the Ranji Trophy since the start of 2024 as the J&K bowler. This season, with 29 scalps in five matches, he is placed second in the wicket charts. EMMANUAL YOGINI

a lot to excel in both aspects,” Nabi told *Sportstar*. “*Pehle dil se start karna hai* (you have to start with the heart). You need to check how the ball is coming out. Then we start with a few steps and then practise hard with the full run-up; it is definitely possible,” he added.

No pacer has picked up as many wickets (73) in the Ranji Trophy since the start of 2024 as the J&K bowler. This season, with 29 scalps in five matches — comfortably more than any other quick bowler — he is placed second in the wicket charts. “[This season] has been going really well. From the first match, the rhythm has been there. In every match, you don’t think that you have to take five wickets. The process is the same. I have to put the ball in a good place. Sometimes you get the result, sometimes you don’t,” Nabi explained.

Participating in the Duleep Trophy ahead of the Ranji season allowed Nabi the opportunity to bowl in tandem with India internationals Arshdeep Singh, Harshit Rana and Anshul Kamboj. “I learnt quite a bit about the mental aspect. They are always relaxed, not thinking about the results. They just believe in themselves,” he observed.

At 29, Nabi is already a good few years into his peak. A relatively late entry into professional cricket meant he was quite unpolished when he made his senior J&K debut in 2018. Born in Baramulla to a schoolteacher father, serious cricket was nowhere on the horizon for young Nabi. It was not until a friend convinced him to attend the state Under-19 trials that he even considered his experience of bowling in tennis-ball cricket might take him somewhere.

“We didn’t have any facilities in Baramulla. The nearest cricket ground was in Srinagar, which was



Guiding right: After a few unexceptional seasons with the ball, Nabi was able to unlock more facets of his game after J&K enlisted P. Krishna Kumar as the bowling coach. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

quite far away (54 km). I had no idea about trials until a friend told me. I tried for two to three years and eventually got in,” Nabi said. “My father used to tell me to focus on studies because where we came from, there was no scope to play cricket. But when I saw players like Parvez Rasool and Abid Nabi, I thought I could do it too, if I worked hard.”

The lack of formal coaching during his formative years made it difficult for Nabi to refine his game on the big stage. Irfan Pathan, who served as coach-mentor for Jammu & Kashmir in 2018-19, was impressed by the young bowler and helped him settle into the senior side. “I received a lot of help from him [Irfan]. He liked my wrist position a lot and used to say I would be able to swing the ball both ways if I worked hard,” Nabi said, recalling the advice the former India pacer shared. After a few

unexceptional seasons with the ball, Nabi was able to unlock more facets of his game after J&K enlisted P. Krishna Kumar as the bowling coach. “We didn’t have a bowling coach until two seasons ago. You can clearly see the improvement in my bowling since he has come in,” Nabi remarked.

A criticism often levelled against swing bowlers of Nabi’s ilk is the lack of searing pace to trouble batters. Many bowlers, past and present, have lost their control trying to find an extra yard of pace. Nabi, whose speed generally ranges from 125-132 kmph, says he will stay clear of making that mistake. “I will choose skill over speed,” he exclaimed.

Coach Krishna Kumar, too, shared the same sentiment. “Speed cannot be a benchmark in selecting a player. Taking five wickets in the Ranji, Duleep and Irani should be the benchmark. If someone has the skill